SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #12 · DEBT AND SHAME

"I must hide my money problems."

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Where it often comes from

Many of us learned that money is private and that trouble should be kept inside the family. Fear of judgment, embarrassment about status, or a parent who always "kept up appearances" can teach us to hide. Hiding can start small, such as not mentioning a bill, and grow into secrecy from a spouse, friends, or church. The cost is isolation and a problem that has no helpers.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed. We are told to bear one another's burdens and that two are better than one, because if one falls, the other can lift him up. James encourages us to confess to one another and pray for one another. None of this means we must tell everyone everything. It means we should not carry heavy things entirely alone, and that wise, safe people are part of God's help.

> *"Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed"* (Proverbs 15:22).

Also see

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ" (Galatians 6:2).

> "For lack of guidance, a nation falls, but with many counselors comes deliverance" (Proverbs 11:14).

> "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!" (Ecclesiastes 4:9–10).

> "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail" (James 5:16).

Common self-statements

- If anyone knew, I would be humiliated.
- I have to look like I have everything under control.
- My spouse cannot handle knowing.
- It is better to say nothing.
- I will fix this quietly.
- People would think less of me.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that others will judge or reject me.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know what people would think.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that being found out would be a disaster.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must handle money problems alone.

Challenging questions

- What am I afraid will happen if one safe person knows?
- What has hiding cost me so far, in peace, sleep, and closeness?
- Who has been honest with me about a hard time, and what did I think of them?

- Who is a safe, wise person I could tell first?
- What is the difference between privacy and secrecy?
- What is the smallest honest step I could take this week?

Truth summary

> Privacy can be healthy, but secrecy about a heavy problem keeps me alone with it. God provides counselors, friends, family, and advisers. I can choose a safe person, share honestly, and let help in.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Help
- Friendship
- Wisdom
- Confession
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Money/Riches
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

What a Friend We Have in Jesus — Keith and Kristyn Getty
This classic hymn invites direct, honest prayer with the Savior who carries our burdens.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I must hide my money problems"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must hide my money problems." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I hiding?
- ☐ What has hiding cost me?
- ☐ Who is a safe person I could tell?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend in my place?
- ☐ What is one honest step this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not have to carry this alone.
- ☐ Wise counsel helps plans succeed.
- ☐ Safe people can carry part of the weight.
- ☐ Honesty is not the same as telling everyone.
- ☐ I can choose who to tell and when.
- ☐ God provides help through people.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 15:22**
  "Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed."
- ☐ **Galatians 6:2**
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- ☐ **Ecclesiastes 4:9–10**
  "Two are better than one, because they have a good return for their labor. For if one falls down, his companion can lift him up; but pity the one who falls without another to help him up!"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I shared: Each week, write down one honest step you took about money, who you told, and how it felt afterward.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 15:22 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Plans succeed with wise counsel, so I can choose a safe person and tell the truth.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Help" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Choose one safe person. Pick someone trustworthy, discreet, and kind, such as a spouse, pastor, counselor, or friend.
- [ ] Write what you want to say. Draft two or three sentences that tell the truth simply.
- [ ] Have the conversation. Share it, ask for support or ideas, and notice how they respond.
- [ ] Seek practical help. Contact a nonprofit credit counselor, financial advisor, or church benevolence team if you need practical guidance.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I must hide my money problems”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	An honest step
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must hide my money problems.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You see what I have been hiding. Give me courage to be honest, and lead me to wise, safe people. Take the shame out of asking for help and let me not carry this alone. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.